

1.1 Drama: character and stagecraft

Paper 1 Drama and Poetry · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Drama meaning arises through spoken lines and performance possibilities: entrances, exits, silence, props, interruptions and audience knowledge. A close response links the precise wording of a line to dramatic position and plausible stage effect, while acknowledging that a script permits more than one performance.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

In an original scene a character silently closes a window as another promises “nothing has changed”: the gesture may contradict the assurance and create tension for an audience.

Original practice stimulus

MAYA: The door was open. (She pockets the key.) ARUN: Then why did you knock? MAYA: I wanted to know whether anyone would answer. (A light appears behind the closed window.) ARUN: There is someone in there. MAYA: You cannot see anyone from here. ARUN: I can see a shadow. (He moves toward the window; she takes one step across his path.) MAYA: Shadows belong to lamps as often as people. ARUN: And keys belong to doors. (A pause. MAYA looks at the pocket of her coat.) MAYA: We should wait until morning. ARUN: You said that yesterday. (The light goes out.)

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Original micro-scene: MAYA: "The door was open." (She pockets the key.) ARUN: [25]
"Then why knock?" Discuss how dialogue and action create uncertainty.

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong essay explores the key as possible concealment, the contradiction between “open” and knocking, and audience knowledge of the stage action. Alternative readings of Maya's motive are welcome when supported; do not assert a single definitive intention.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

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<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/636097-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

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